

3

MENTAL MODELS OF OBJECTS AND THE MEANING OF “SELF”



Hopefully the new concepts and terminology I’ve introduced so far are starting to make sense. Some people new to OOP have trouble envisioning what an object is and how the methods of an object work with its instance variables. The specifics are fairly complex, so it can be helpful to develop a mental model of how objects and classes operate.

In this chapter, I’ll present two mental models of OOP. Right up front, I want to be clear that neither of these models is an exact representation of how objects work in Python. Instead, these models are intended to give you a way to think about what an object looks like and what happens when you call a method. This chapter will also go into more detail about `self` and show how it is used to make methods work with multiple objects instantiated from the same class. Throughout the rest of the book, you’ll gain a much deeper insight into objects and classes.